think. It gives you all your capacity for wonder. My mother had a gift for love and for making life no less interesting than it was. You can't take that for granted. Some people press their children into dullness before they've even opened their mouths. And there's probably something to be said for Magnetic Island itself at that time: it was a freedom-haunted place, a beautiful Eden of about a thousand inhabitants, where people who didn't fit in any place else came to live. It might have been a lush and forgotten hippy republic, and I can't discount its early influence; like hoop pines or cabbage palms, a child will tend to hang as he grows, and something of Magnetic Island would stay with me.

My first word was 'Why?' It was also my favourite. And though I didn't love the play pen, I loved the books that my mother would store in there beside me. I learned to read that way, with Ladybird books, supplemented later with Tarzan and Dr Seuss and *Animal Farm*. From the beginning we moved around a lot, but Magnetic Island – named by James Cook, who thought it interfered with his compasses – was a place to come back to. When I was two my mother met a man called Brett Assange, a musician and travelling theatre guy who proved a good stepfather to me. A lot of my family's energy was devoted to the life outdoors. We swam every day and later I fished with my grandfather in the Sandon River or at Shark Beach. I remember rolling down the hills with my mother on her bike, and as we sped along I would stretch out my hands and try to grasp fruit from the trees overhead. We trekked from one place to another, always, for me, with a sense of discovery, the perennial 'Why?' never far from my lips. My parents weren't shy of 'Why?' They would lay out the possibilities and let me decide for myself.

By the time I was five I had already lived in many houses. I think we had a sense of North Queensland being a moveable feast: I carried the climate with me and just breathed curiosity. My mother wasn't a constant activist, but she knew the power of change. Around then, living for a time in Adelaide, we went door-knocking to stop uranium mining. We banned tuna from our house because of the harm the fishing nets did to dolphins, and later, when the blockade forced a change in fishing practices, we rejoiced and felt our own efforts had played a part in producing the result. Another time, in Lismore, my mother was jailed for four days as a result of her participation in a protest to stop logging in rainforests. I'd say it was a